How I Remember Meta DE Stories

5 COMPANIES = 5 STORIES = ALL COMPETENCIES

Lazada | Makro | SCB | DBS | PayPal



Meta DE interviews score multipliers, not just shippers.

MULTIPLIER TEST

Senior DE who makes 3 juniors better > ships 3x code alone.

Mentorship = docs + review rubric + systems others can extend + naming who taught you.

A

CREDIT-HOG RED FLAG

Says “I” for everything. Never names WHO did WHAT.

B

CREDIT-AVOIDER RED FLAG

Says “we” for everything. Hides impact, avoids ownership.

✓

FIX

Name person, level, interest + public miss ownership. **If it disappeared tomorrow, what breaks for whom?**

L6 differentiator: fair credit = specific about who did what + public ownership of a miss. Mentorship is primary job, not side hobby.

LAZADA = LIFT

Mentorship & Fair Credit

E-commerce scale, fast juniors. Lead DE migrating Redshift-Postgres → Snowflake + dbt

SITUATION Team: **Priya** (2y), **Marco** (3y), **Aisha** new grad + 4 analysts dependent on old pipeline

TASK Ship in **12 weeks**, zero downtime, grow team skills, keep analyst trust

ACTION **Divide by interest + growth:** Aisha = docs & data tests (learning surface), Priya = incremental marts + macros (stretch), Marco = cutover runbook (growth to senior).
My role: system design + 3 hardest PRs + review rubric (why + link) as teaching tool

MISS Week 10 partial outage – my missed review. Public postmortem + added staging load test to runbook



0
analyst complaints, zero downtime

9mo
Aisha L3 promo, Priya internal conf

3x
review rubric adopted by 3 teams

Recognition: Public demo naming, macro open-sourced under Priya's name, nominated Aisha for rising award – she won. Owned miss publicly in leadership channel.

Why Lazada wins the multiplier test

POLISHED 1-LINER TO MEMORIZE

“I divided work by interest & growth, held riskiest pieces, made review a teaching tool, gave public credit including ownership of miss”

Reflection line: Team output bounded by weakest reviewer; mentorship is highest-leverage infra work.

> *If this project disappeared tomorrow, what would break and for whom? – answer: 4 analysts lose trust, juniors lose growth path*

1 INTENTIONAL

Names, levels, why that piece

Aisha docs & tests = interest + highest learning surface. Priya macros = strength + stretch. Marco runbook = growth to senior. Not delegation, mentorship design.

2 LIFT AS YOU CLIMB

Public credit you could have taken

Demo naming, Priya macro open-sourced under her name, Aisha nominated rising award – won. Visible work rotated by promo need, not ego.

3 OWN MISS

Fairness about failure = strongest signal

Week 10 outage: my missed review. Said exact words in postmortem channel + added staging load test. No hiding.

4 QUANTIFIED

People + system outcomes

0 downtime, 0 complaints. Aisha L3 in 9mo. Priya conf talk. Rubric adopted by 3 teams. Promotion committee signal.

MAKRO = OWN

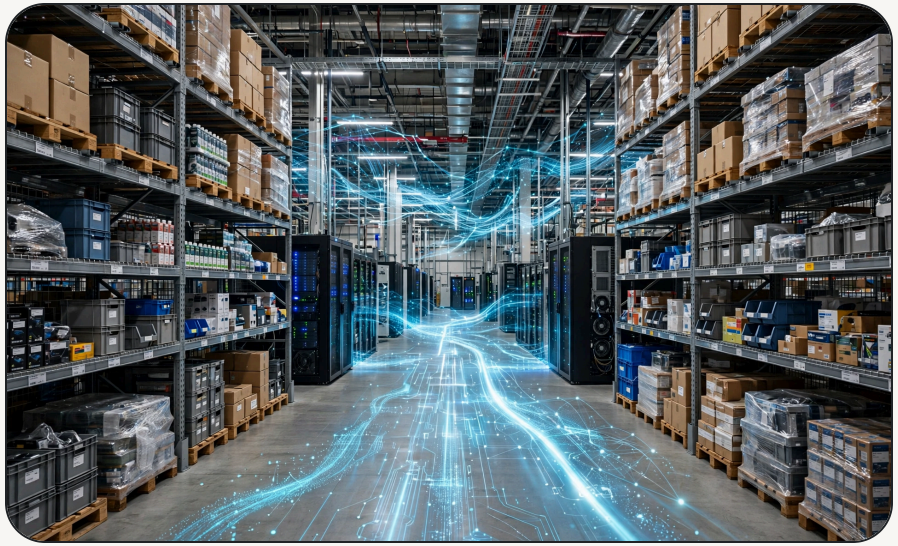
Ownership & Prioritization

Wholesale data, messy attribution. Growth marketing 6hrs/week manual pulls from 3 ad platforms + events pipeline + broken Looker.

TASK Vague “self-serve attribution” – no SLA, conflicting models. **Write the spec yourself.**

ACTION 2-week discovery, 8 stakeholders. 1-pager with **5 KPIs + SQL examples** for sign-off. Built dbt mart on Airflow/Snowflake, dbt tests caught **4% revenue leak day 2**. Partnered with Analytics Eng to deprecate after 80% adoption.

RESULT Manual reporting died. Flagship for promo cycle.



6h → 0
manual reporting per week

40+ WAU
in 2 months adoption

$180K/q
misattributed spend recovered

Lesson: When spec is unclear, highest leverage = write the spec yourself then socialize it. Ambiguity removal is ownership.

SCB = SHIM

Conflict, Persuasion Without Authority



Bank · payments data · 2 upstream schemas → 3% double-count.
Dashboards wrong for 8 months. 3 stakeholders, 3 pressures.

SITUATION Analytics revenue dashboards built on buggy data. Finance cares about history, service owners care about cost.

TASK **Fix root cause + decide backfill + tell analytics their numbers wrong** – without formal authority.

RESULT Quick fix **6 days**, 90-day backfill 3 weeks. Dashboards re-annotated. Analytics lead nominated me for cross-team award.

ACTION PLAYBOOK – NO AMBUSH

1. Pre-meet separately – analytics lead + 2 service owners (reduce asymmetry first)
2. 1-pager: $ impact + reproducible SQL + **2 options**: quick fix 1wk vs full 6wks
3. Let each owner pick – joined analytics meeting to absorb questions together

92% impact — **Shim compromise: backfill last 90 days = 92% of impact at 18% compute cost. Math-based, not seniority-based. Finance accepted.**

3% error
double-count from schema version drift

6 days
quick fix shipped, no trust broken

18% cost
for 92% impact via 90-day shim

"Most conflict is information conflict. Reduce asymmetry before negotiating positions."

DBS = MEMO

0 → 1 Data Initiative

Bank, no experiment platform existed. Narrative before code.

Before: nothing | **After: people depend on it** | **40 eng-days/yr wasted**

SITUATION Frankenstein: **3 Python scripts, 4 analysts, 4 notebooks**, 2 days per experiment, **3 conflicting "active user"** defs in board deck

TASK Build unified experimentation data product from scratch. No one asked. Had to make case for 0.5 FTE

ACTION **2-pager:** quantified cost. Got director backing. Designed contracts: taxonomy, user-resolution, exposure. **Shim 90-day** old → new to neutralize senior analyst blocker. **Cut v1:** exposure tables + 1 func + 3 templates. No UI/Grafana/SLA. Migrated 1 team myself



10 wks
v1 shipped

2d → 4h
turnaround time

2/4
teams migrated 3mo

Polished line: "I saw cost no one quantified, wrote case, designed contracts, shim to neutralize blocker, cut scope by half, migrated first team myself." Reflection: 0 → 1 work is mostly narrative work.

PAYPAL = TRACE

Tight deadline + ramp-up

Real-time fraud, billions events. Scala/Akka 4yr codebase, 3w to board demo

SITUATION / TASK

Joined new team owning ingest. Had to **learn 4yr Scala/Akka**, protect **99.95% SLO**, ship tested PR before demo.

RAMP PLAYBOOK – MY SYSTEM

1. **Trace 3 events end-to-end**, not top-down reading
2. **Draw data-flow diagram** + 2-page "how this works" doc
3. 30-min office hrs with 2 experts – **12 specific Qs**
4. Read last **50 PRs + 20 postmortems**
5. Pair-program streaming join – caught watermark bug

Prioritize: Listed 8 things → killed 6 with tech lead. V1 = **score, log, alert** only. No UI, backfill, dashboard.



4d early
shipped before board demo

0
incidents first month

$1.2M/mo
fraud caught, ramp doc = onboarding

> *"Trace one transaction end-to-end, draw it, then ask experts the questions the diagram raises"*

4 must-have artifacts in your pocket

If you walk in without these, you will generic-answer.
Bring specifics, not slogans.

1 — MENTEE DELTA

Specific before → after skill delta

Not "I mentored them". Show trajectory, what you gave, how you measured.

Aisha: docs & data-tests (her interest) → L3 in 9mo. You gave review rubric (why + link) + nomination for rising award

2 — VISIBLE CREDIT YOU SKIPPED

Credit you could have taken

Concrete, recent. Shows lift-as-you-climb, not credit-hog.

Priya's dbt macro open-sourced under HER name. Demo: named person → metric. Conference talk under her name.

3 — YOU WERE MENTORED

Time you received mentorship + changed

Signals you can be mentored – critical L5→L6 signal.

Senior review comment: "every comment needs why + link". I built rubric doc → adopted by 3 teams. Cite who taught you.

4 — PUBLIC MISS

Own a miss publicly – exact words

Strongest fair-credit signal. Have postmortem quote ready.

Week 10 outage: "Cause was review I missed. I added staging-env load test to runbook." Said in leadership channel.

BONUS → 1-pager for leadership you wrote (problem + SQL + options) · Scope you cut + why (framework, not "felt right") · 60s / 3min / 6min versions of each story ready

INTERVIEW DEFENSE

Variations & Red Flags

If interviewer pushes past STAR, have framework + real miss ready. Generic answers fail L6 bar.

VARIATIONS INTERVIEWER PUSHES

1. **“Feedback junior doesn't want?”**
   Behavior + Impact + What got in way – not sandwich. Specific story.

2. **“Mentee didn't work out?”**
   Honest + kind. What I learned about matching/hiring signal, not blame.

3. **“Who gets visible work?”**
   Rotation / growth area / who needs visibility for promo. Never “I’m best at hard stuff”.

4. **“Director didn't back you?” / “What NOT to build?”**
   Weekend prototype + beachhead analyst. Framework: adoption first, ergonomics later.

RED FLAGS – INSTANT L5

- Generic “I love mentoring” no names, levels, before/after delta
- Claiming credit you didn't influence / inflating mentee titles
- “I delegated” with no setup detail – no docs, rubric, growth mapping
- No miss / no postmortem link. Fairness about failure is strongest signal
- Mentorship as side hobby, not primary job. 0→1 where you joined existing team
- Scope cut no reasoning. Conflict where other side looks incompetent

Remember: If project disappeared tomorrow, what breaks and for whom? Answer must name person + pain.

Use this sentence structure in interview

Copy-paste STAR + credit line. Say WHO did WHAT. Ends with reflection. 60s / 3min / 6min versions ready.

S SITUATION

[Company] + mess + who

Lazada: Redshift→Snowflake, 3 eng + 4 analysts. Makro: 6h manual pull. SCB: 3% double-count 8mo.

Ex: "Lazada – legacy Redshift, 2 mid + 1 new grad, 4 analysts blocked"

T TASK

Ship X in Y weeks + skills

Quantify: zero downtime + grow team + trust. DBS: no one asked. Had to make case.

Ex: "Ship in 12w, 0 downtime, grow dbt skills, 0 complaints"

A ACTION

Your system, not generic

Divide by interest+growth. I took riskiest. Rubric, 1-pager, shim, cut scope 50%, migrate first team.

Ex: "Aisha docs/tests, Priya macros, Marco runbook – my design + 3 hardest PRs"

R RESULT

Time + $ + people

6h→0, 40+ WAU, $180K/q, 0 incidents. People: L3 promo, conf talk, award. Adoption: 3 teams.

Ex: "On time, 0 complaints, Aisha L3 9mo, rubric adopted 3 teams"

C CREDIT LINE

Always end with reflection

"Reflection: Team output bounded by weakest reviewer; mentorship is highest-leverage infra work"

Add public miss: week10 outage my review miss + staging test fix. Fairness about failure = L6 signal.

💡 **Filter question:** If project disappeared tomorrow, what would break and for whom? Answer must name analysts, revenue, trust.

🎯 **L6 differentiator:** Name person, level, why that piece. Visible credit you could have taken. Public demo naming + macro under her name.

META DE BEHAVIORAL – MEMORY SYSTEM

5 words to remember

LAZADA

Lift

Make 3 juniors better. Divide by growth, teach via review.

MAKRO

Own

Write the spec. Highest leverage when goal is vague.

SCB

Shim

Enlarge, don't compete. 92% impact at 18% cost.

DBS

Memo

Narrative before code. If you can't write it, it won't get built.

PAYPAL

Trace

One transaction end-to-end. Then ask the diagram's questions.

- Final mantra: **Divide by growth, hold risk, teach via review, give credit publicly, own miss publicly**

Lazada = Mentorship · Makro = Ownership · SCB = Conflict · DBS = 0→1 · PayPal = Deadline + Ramp